

ETHNO ECOLOGY

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ETHICS, ECOLOGY, AND THE FUTURE: ART AND DESIGN FACE THE ANTHROPOCENE

In *Ethics, Ecology, and the Future: Art and Design Face the Anthropocene*, Kayla Ande describes the socio-political and environmental long-term implications speculated through means of art and design materialized in the projects of artists and designers such as Marina Zurkow, Una Chaudhuri, Oliver Kellhammer, Fritz Erti and Sarah Rothberg; Anthony Dunne and Fiona Raby; and Jae Rhim Lee. These artists and designers approach the social and parasocial relationships with technology and science that we, as humankind, have developed within the Anthropocene.

The main argument hovering over the presence of such speculative projects is not necessarily building a critical view that would engage us further into doing anything that stands in our power as a society to keep control over what we currently judge as potential danger in regards to the dynamics that homogenize amongst humankind and western technology, but rather explore the imaginary scenarios that split from technology advancement. The forementioned artists and designers bring into the scene tools for analysis and unpicking not only what could happen in radically tech-infused futures, but more importantly in the cases we will further discuss, tools for diverging the evolution of our own personal and emotional judgements of such scenarios.

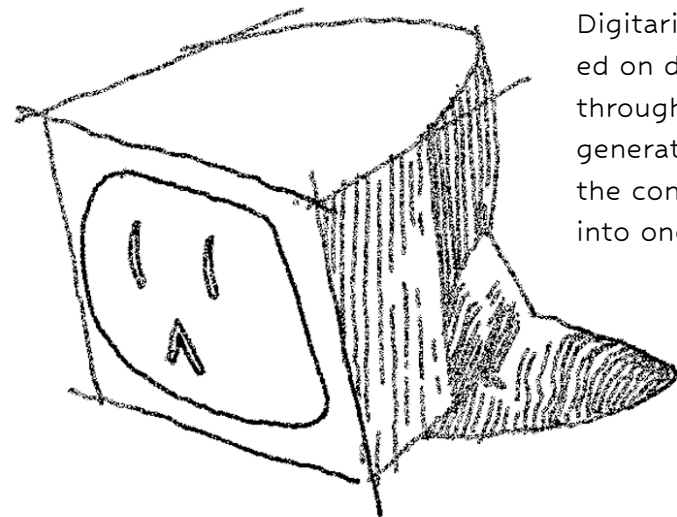
The word Anthropocene (Anthropos = human; cene = new) used in the year 2000 by Dutch chemist and Nobel prize-winner Paul Crutzen, must not be mistaken as a signification of human dominance over the geological environment. (Anderson, 2015) The geological force that humans extrude is not in our control, yet the name change of our epoch acts as "a strong reminder to the general public that we are now having undeniable impacts on the environment at the scale of the planet as a whole", says the Head of Australia National University's Climate Change Institute Will Steffen. (ibid.)

Both Timothy Morton and Joana Żylińska criticize the outcomes of the intense technological development within the modern society as "damaged thinking" (Morton, 2010) and "crisis of critical thinking". (Żylińska, 2014) Żylińska suggests we approach the Anthropocene through "a different mode of philosophizing, one that produces ideas with things and events rather than just with words", (ibid.) through "non-instrumental modes of thinking" to avoid the "easy solutionism and what some theorists have called derangement of scale". (ibid.) The use of the word solutionism (and/or masculinism) in regard to narrative of the Anthropocene is meant to divide the faculties of thinking understood under the premisses of heroic desire to solve a complex and wide-spread problem (for example climate change), from its contextual counterpart of provoking discussion and radical thought experiments. (ibid.)

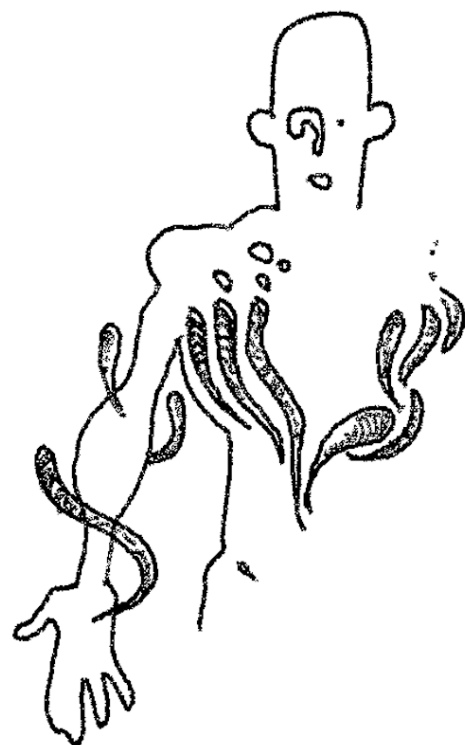
Anthony Dunne and Fiona Raby label their work as "design" rather than "art" in *Speculative Everything* reasoned as "We expect art to be shocking and extreme. Critical design needs to be closer to the everyday ; that's where it's power to disturb lies". (Dunne and Raby, 2013) Viewing design as disturbances in the systems of living today, highlighting the fundamental aspect of design known as forever-changing. (ibid.) The artists behind *Dear Climate*, Jae Rhim Lee, Dunne and Raby emphasize the future's dynamic positioning between Utopian and uncanny, rich in questions rather than solutions. It not solving the problems that makes "critical", "speculative" and "conceptual" design relevant, but its intellectual strength lies in the constructive appeal of unboxing the issues observed at first or second glance looking at the shape of the Anthropocene. (Dunne and Raby, 2007)

The notion "movement of mind" rather than call for action - one might read as thinkivist rather than activist, therefore *Dead Climate* suggests social, political and geographical reorganization in order to adapt to climate change, and not conquer it. Henceforth we have the idea of appealing to human agency over the human "many efforts to respond to the Anthropocene actually mobilize a certain notion of specieist, or more precisely humanist, self-interest. . .principally driven by species narcissism, or a desire for human survival", states Żylińska. (2014) Talking about humanism and survival of the human species, positively in balanced co-habitation with other species, in his essay *Some Trace Effects of the Post-Anthropocene: On Accelerationist Geopolitical Aesthetics*, Benjamin Bratton states, "the best of all possible news is that, should 'we' survive the Anthropocene, it will not be as 'humans'". (2013)

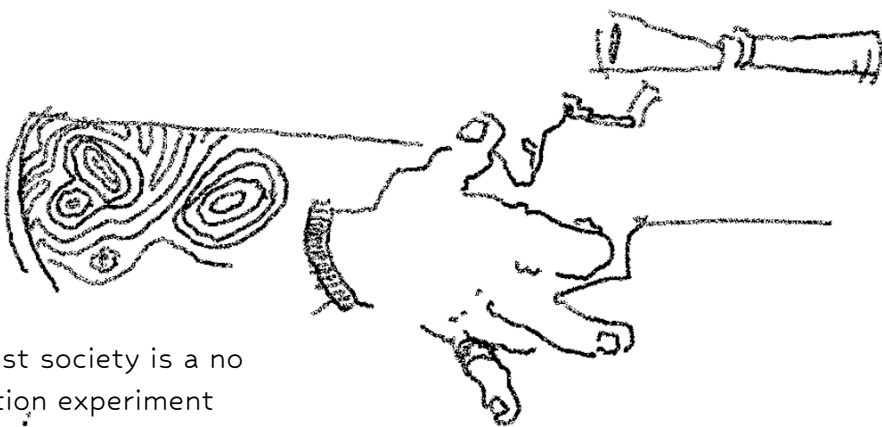
United Micro Kingdoms (UMK; Dunne and Raby, 2013) present four “fictional future” populations of England in radical cyborgian and/or unconventional ways through witty and intentionally far-fetched technological routes to the extreme to reveal tech-based cultural and ethical impacts that could radically alter our daily lives:



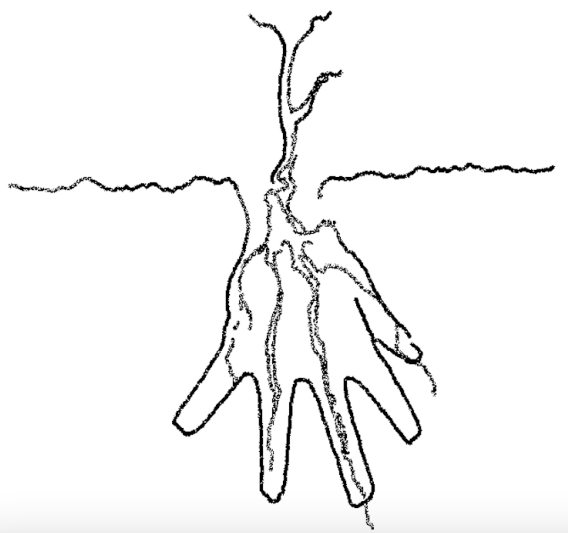
Digitarians who are completely depend-
ed on digital technology and totalitarianism
through robust forms of surveillance
generating 100% transparency, merging
the concepts of citizen and consumer
into one.



The Anarcho-evolutionists abandon
most technologies, but rather exercise
to advance their own physical capaci-
ties through cyborgian means in order
to adapt to the changing environment.
They abandoned the belief that the
world as it is, in this particular specu-
lation, could re-establish to their own
human condition.



The Communo-nuclearist society is a no
growth, limited population experiment
that exploits nuclear power limitlessly and
are provided by the state to survive. Yet
at such power capacity they undoubtedly
wear an aura of risk of attack or accident.



Bioliberals fully embrace biotechnology.
Biology lie in the center of their living
systems and they produce their own en-
ergy to sustain their particular lifestyles.
Gardens kitchens and farm replace facto-
ries and workshops.

Dunne addresses that utopias and manifestos have decreased in relevance, and perpet-
ual capitalism seems inevitable. He states “by directing the project at people’s imagina-
tions. . .we can potentially open up perspectives on how the world is”. (Dunne 2013-14)

TOWARDS A MINOR URBANISM PUBLIC SPACE AS WORLD EXPO: SUPERKILEN

Superkilen (The Super Wedge) is a colorful and unconventional public space in central Copenhagen opened in 2012. It is financed by the City of Copenhagen and the Danish association Realdania; and designed by the Danish architectural practice Bjarke Ingels Group (BIG), the Danish artist collective SUPERPLEX, and the German landscape architectural studio Topotek. The blueprint of Superkilen portrays a linear 750m-long park of three distinct but connected parts, each in a different color - red, black, and green. It contains 108 everyday objects from around the world (out of which 103 are replicas, and five are objects brought from afar). The parts conclude a relation between far-flung places, with a wide range of activities assigned to each element such as a square dancing, cycling, boxing, basketball, chess, and barbecuing, while others relate to more general activities like walking, resting, and playing. At the place one can also find a café and a sports hall, Nørrebrohallen. In 2013 Superkilen was nominated for the prestigious Mies van der Rohe Architecture Prize, and it won the Aga Khan Award for Architecture. Due to its out-of-the-ordinary diversity in terms of ethnicity and transcultural implications, the location Nørrebro (more specifically Mjølnerparken) known as a “ghetto” with a “history of hard-core working class” is now a dramatically safer and more child-friendly environment. (Sandström, 2019)

For us who grew up in Copenhagen in the fifties and sixties, Nørrebro appears in a special light. ... In Nørrebro you were not easily shocked, you'd seen it all before. There was no room for snobs. But there was lots of tolerance. Today, Nørrebro is totally changed ... the tolerance has gone. (Kjærsgaard in Schmidt, 2011)

The visitor is exposed to a high of objects with strong political connotations: Kurdish benches, soil from Palestine and play equipment from Pripyat, an abandoned town close to Chernobyl. Realdania's representative Astrid Bruus Thomsen suggest an idea of living-together in localized global scenario through exposure to politically charged pieces of design: “If you have soil from Palestine or a manhole from Israel, will some people spit on it. Yeah, maybe, but still, of course, we hope nobody would do this. The idea is that everybody respects that we are coexisting together”. (Steiner, 2013)

In an interview with a 12-year-old girl with Iraqi roots named Sarah she points her positive reaction to some of the elements present at Superkilen:

I like that house (pointing to the dance pavilion). We always drink milkshakes and sit there. You can watch the basketball games from there, but I am most happy because there is something from Iraq here, the swings! I know there is soil from Palestine too. I really like to see something from Iraq here. I think I like to use the swings because they are from Iraq. (Interview 8 May 2015)

Sandström emphasizes on the term “Fragmentation” through her interpretation of Defner and Hoerning: “the fragment is a reminder of a former entity, but it represents a current state in which ‘broken pieces’ start to form new patterns, thus indicating a process of reconstruction”. Being a term often used to summarize the phenomena of societal and spatial segregation, one could argue the presentation of Superkilen as curated in the shape of an outdoors/open museum. (2019)

Parts can be removed without collapsing or changing the whole. This encapsulation of internal units is an advantage, as it allows heterogeneity to be sustained without being confrontational. (Hancock, 2010)

THE RELATIONAL PARK: JUBILEUMSPARKEN

Jubileumsparken (The Jubilee Park) is a temporary pre-run park in Gothenburg, designed in advance of a city park scheduled for completion in 2021. The temporary park is created by the public developer Älvstranden Tvecklings AB in cooperation with the city planning authorities in Gothenburg; and can be found near the former dockyards as part of Frihamnen, a 30-hectare harbour area originating from the early 1920s. The area is mainly industrial and surrounded by traffic infrastructure for cars and large vehicles, but also the remains of the old harbour and water. The municipality describes it as a spot for “place-building” (platsbyggande) and the design scheme centres on the notion of “urban prototypes”, where ideas can be materialized directly into real-scale prototypes, some of which I can mention are: a sauna, a play structure, a swimming pool, and an infrastructure that enables urban gardening, biking and sailing.

Rather than delivering a written report of two hundred pages, we report in reality. You should be able to step into the planning. (Segerlund in Janson, 2014)

(Temporary use initiatives) rely on the principle of spontaneous action by a group of participants and develop their vitality precisely through their renunciation of determining and enclosure a long-term ideal plan. (Fezer, 2012)

The central question at Jubileumsparken is diversity, as the director of Passalen argues that diversity stands on the pillars of conscious work: “In order for diversity to organize itself, we must organize diversity.” (12 July 2018; Sandström, 2019) The architecture collective MYCKET base their strategy on the belief that “only where there is space for the particular is there space for everyone.”

There is so much talk about how wrong it is with segregation, but there are people who don't feel safe in any of the usual public spaces – therefore spaces must be made where it is rather normative uses that are excluded. (Interview 17 September 2015, my translation; ibid.)

Sandström argues that a place designed for everyone is never neutral in terms of social norms and symbolic representations, as even if one group is targeted as designated for, the outcome of urban design always falls at the risk of fostering some better than others. This may as well come from a group's ability to present their norms as universal, making themselves look as a more general public. (2019) Feminist theorist Sandra Harding suggests that the needs of marginalized groups should be prioritized as they help envision a more genuine image of the world due to their outsider-within position. (Harding, 2004)

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